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**AS AMENDED**

BILL NO. 2125

and

Sacchieri of the Senate

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

Section 6-122.3. A. The State Board of Education shall grant an alternative placement teaching certificate to a person who makes application to the Board and meets the following criteria:

- 1       1.    a.   holds at least a baccalaureate degree from an  
2                   institution whose accreditation is recognized by the  
3                   Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education and has  
4                   attained a retention grade point average of not less  
5                   than 2.50 on a 4.0 scale, or  
6            b.   has successfully completed a terminal degree, such as  
7                   a doctorate of philosophy, a doctorate in education,  
8                   professional doctorates, a master of fine arts degree  
9                   or a master of library science degree, from an  
10                  institution accredited by a national or regional  
11                  accrediting agency which is recognized by the  
12                  Secretary of the United States Department of  
13                  Education. The Oklahoma State Regents for Higher  
14                  Education shall be consulted to verify other terminal  
15                  degrees, or  
16            c.   holds at least a baccalaureate degree from an  
17                   institution whose accreditation is recognized by the  
18                   Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education and has  
19                   qualified work experience in a field that corresponds  
20                   to an area of certification as determined by the State  
21                   Board of Education, and  
22            d.   in addition to the requirements of subparagraphs a, b  
23                   and c of this paragraph, has demonstrated competency  
24                   or completed a major in a field that corresponds to an

1 area of specialization for an Elementary-Secondary  
2 Certificate or a Secondary Certificate as determined  
3 by the State Board of Education or a vocational-  
4 technical certificate as recommended by the Oklahoma  
5 Department of Career and Technology Education;

6 2. Declares the intention to earn standard certification by  
7 means of an alternative placement program in not more than three (3)  
8 years. The State Board of Education shall determine the subject  
9 matter and the number of clock or semester hours required for the  
10 professional education component for each person making application  
11 for an alternative placement teaching certificate based on the  
12 criteria of paragraph 1 of this subsection.

13 The State Board of Education shall establish a core minimum of  
14 six (6) semester hours or ninety (90) clock hours and a maximum of  
15 eighteen (18) semester hours or two hundred seventy (270) clock  
16 hours for the professional education component.

17 The requirements set forth in this subsection shall exclude all  
18 student teaching requirements pursuant to the provisions of  
19 subsection E of this section;

20 3. Has passed the subject area portion of the competency  
21 examination required in Section 6-187 of this title in the area of  
22 specialization for which certification is sought; and

23 4. Either presents a document from an accredited public school  
24 district in this state offering employment in the area of

1 specialization for which certification is sought on condition that  
2 the person enroll in an alternative placement program approved by  
3 the State Board of Education or declares the intention to seek  
4 employment as a teacher at an accredited public school district in  
5 this state. The certificate granted pursuant to this subsection  
6 shall be considered a "valid certificate of qualification" for the  
7 purposes of Sections 6-107 and 6-108 of this title, and the holder  
8 of the certificate shall be considered an inductee for the purposes  
9 of Section 6-195 of this title.

10 B. An alternative placement teaching certificate shall be  
11 renewed for not more than a maximum of three (3) years upon  
12 presentation of a document from an accredited public school district  
13 in this state offering renewed employment in the same area of  
14 specialization and a document from a teacher education institution  
15 verifying satisfactory progress in an appropriate alternative  
16 placement program.

17 C. Persons enrolled in an alternative placement program shall:

18 1. Have never been denied admittance to a teacher education  
19 program approved by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education,  
20 the North Central Association of Colleges and Schools and by the  
21 Oklahoma Commission for Teacher Preparation to offer teacher  
22 education programs, nor have enrolled in and subsequently failed  
23 courses necessary to successfully meet the minimum requirements of  
24 the program, except those persons who hold a certificate;

1        2. Have on file with the director of teacher education at an  
2 Oklahoma institution of higher education a plan for meeting standard  
3 certification requirements within three (3) years; and

4        3. Participate in an induction program as required in Section  
5 6-195 of this title and have the same duties and responsibilities as  
6 other inductees.

7        D. The State Board of Education may grant an exception to the  
8 requirements for certification and, upon demonstration by an  
9 individual of specific competency in the subject area of  
10 specialization, may grant a certificate to the individual. The  
11 State Board may establish other requirements necessary to grant  
12 exceptions.

13        E. The State Board of Education, in consultation with the  
14 Commission for Educational Quality and Accountability, may grant an  
15 exception to the requirement to complete a subject area examination  
16 for initial certification in a field which does not require an  
17 advanced degree pursuant to this section if the candidate has an  
18 advanced degree in a subject that is substantially comparable to the  
19 content assessed on a subject area examination. The degree shall be  
20 from an institution accredited by a national or regional accrediting  
21 agency which is recognized by the Secretary of the U.S. Department  
22 of Education. The Commission shall provide the Board with the  
23 necessary information to determine comparability.

1 F. Student teaching and a prestudent teaching field experience  
2 shall not be required of alternative placement program participants  
3 for standard certification.

4 G. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules  
5 authorizing adjunct teachers who shall be persons with distinguished  
6 qualifications in their field. Adjunct teachers shall be authorized  
7 to teach at all grade levels including in early childhood education  
8 programs. Provided, however, an adjunct teacher employed to teach  
9 in an early childhood education program shall be required to enroll  
10 in a State Department of Education approved training on the  
11 cognitive science of how students learn to read during his or her  
12 first year of employment as an adjunct teacher and complete the  
13 training by the end of his or her second year of employment as an  
14 adjunct teacher. An adjunct teacher who fails to complete the  
15 training after two (2) years of employment shall be prohibited from  
16 teaching in an early childhood education program until the training  
17 has been completed. Adjunct teachers shall not be authorized to  
18 teach special education classes. Adjunct teachers shall not be  
19 required to meet standard certification. A person employed as an  
20 adjunct teacher pursuant to this subsection who does not hold a  
21 valid certificate to teach shall not be considered a teacher as  
22 defined by Section 1-116 of this title.

23 H. Each teacher education institution shall provide the  
24 Oklahoma Commission for Teacher Preparation an annual report of

1 information as specified by the Commission regarding participation  
2 in the alternative placement programs offered by the institution.

3 I. The Oklahoma Commission for Teacher Preparation shall not  
4 accredit, renew the accreditation of, or otherwise approve any  
5 teacher education program of any institution of higher education in  
6 this state that has not implemented alternative placement programs  
7 in at least four areas of specialization including mathematics,  
8 science and a foreign language. Each institution shall allow  
9 individuals who meet the criteria of subsections A and C of this  
10 section to be:

11 1. Admitted to an alternative placement program without further  
12 qualification; and

13 2. Offered the opportunity to complete the requirements for  
14 standard certification set forth in subsection A of this section  
15 during the summer preceding and the summer following the first year  
16 of teaching with an alternative placement teaching certificate. Any  
17 person seeking standard certification through an alternative  
18 placement program shall be permitted to take necessary courses  
19 during regular semesters if offered.

20 J. The criteria specified in subsection I of this section can  
21 be met through a cooperative arrangement entered into by two or more  
22 institutions of higher education.

23 SECTION 2. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 11-103.7, is  
24 amended to read as follows:

1       Section 11-103.7. A. Each school district may offer to four-  
2 year-old children the opportunity to participate in an early  
3 childhood education program.

4       B. The State Board of Education shall promulgate standards for  
5 early childhood education programs for children who are at least  
6 four (4) years of age on or before September 1 of the ensuing school  
7 year. The standards shall include both half-day programs consisting  
8 of not less than two and one-half (2 1/2) hours per school day, and  
9 full-day programs of six (6) hours. The standards for all early  
10 childhood education programs shall require a certified teacher, as  
11 specified in this section, or an adjunct teacher as authorized by  
12 subsection G of Section 6-122.3 of this title to be present in the  
13 classroom for the length of the school day. Such program shall:

14       1. Be directed toward developmentally appropriate objectives  
15 for such children, rather than toward academic objectives suitable  
16 for older children;

17       2. Accommodate the needs of all children and families  
18 regardless of socioeconomic circumstances; and

19       3. Require that any teacher employed by a public school to  
20 teach in such early childhood education program shall be certified  
21 in early childhood education.

22       C. The superintendent of any school district providing  
23 classroom space or other school facilities for a federally sponsored  
24 Head Start program that is planning to make a material change in the



1 arrangement, shall give notice to the director of the Head Start  
2 program at least seven (7) days prior to a school board hearing on  
3 the matter.

4 D. A school district may offer such early childhood education  
5 program within the district, in cooperation with other districts,  
6 through the use of transfers as specified by law, or by contracting  
7 with a private or public provider of early childhood education  
8 programs, or by contracting for classroom space with a licensed  
9 public or private child care provider based upon selection criteria  
10 established by the district. If the program is provided through  
11 contract with a private or public provider other than a school  
12 district, the contract may only be continued if each teacher serving  
13 the school on and after January 1, 1993, is certified in early  
14 childhood education, except that all teachers, without such  
15 certification, hired by such provider prior to January 1, 1993, and  
16 serving in the school as an early childhood education teacher shall  
17 be required to obtain certification on or before the beginning of  
18 the 1996-97 school year. Any person who has been employed as an  
19 early childhood educator with the Head Start ~~Program~~ program, has a  
20 child development associate degree (CDA) and has at least five (5)  
21 years of experience in such employment shall be certified in early  
22 childhood education for purposes of employment in the public schools  
23 of this state to teach in early childhood education for children  
24 four (4) years of age and younger; if such person is recertified in

1 child development by the Council for Early Childhood Professional  
2 Recognition within five (5) years prior to the expiration of the  
3 person's early childhood certificate that was issued by the State  
4 Board of Education, such person shall be granted a renewal  
5 certificate in early childhood education by the State Board of  
6 Education upon expiration of the early childhood certificate.  
7 Provided, private or public providers shall meet such other  
8 standards required by law and by the State Board of Education.

9 E. If an early childhood education program is provided by a  
10 private or public provider pursuant to a contract as authorized in  
11 this section, the contract shall address the requirements for  
12 implementing the induction program as required in Section 6-195 of  
13 this title. Teachers employed by a private or public provider in an  
14 early childhood education program provided through contract with a  
15 public school district shall receive in salary and/or fringe  
16 benefits amounts not less than the amounts specified in the schedule  
17 set forth in Section ~~18-114.14~~ 18-114.15 of this title.

18 F. The State Board of Education shall promulgate rules to  
19 provide for the implementation of such program.

20 G. An early childhood education program may be offered jointly  
21 by school districts that have formed interlocal cooperative  
22 agreements pursuant to Section 5-117b of this title.

23 H. The term "prekindergarten" shall mean early childhood  
24 education for purposes of this title.

1 I. The State Board of Education shall ensure that the standards  
2 for early childhood education are aligned with any new subject  
3 matter standards adopted pursuant to Section 11-103.6a of this  
4 title.

5 SECTION 3. This act shall become effective July 1, 2025.

6 SECTION 4. It being immediately necessary for the preservation  
7 of the public peace, health or safety, an emergency is hereby  
8 declared to exist, by reason whereof this act shall take effect and  
9 be in full force from and after its passage and approval.

10 COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON EDUCATION  
11 April 15, 2025 - DO PASS AS AMENDED  
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